

SOLVED PRACTICE WORKBOOK

Foundation of the Delhi Sultanate: The Slave (Mamluk) Dynasty - Learner-v2 Refreshed

UPSC complete learning session | Foundation to advanced | Concepts, evidence, practice and answer writing

Foundation of the Delhi Sultanate: The Slave (Mamluk) Dynasty	
REFRESHED TEACHING NAVIGATION — BASIC/CORE FIRST	
01	SCOPE, TERMINOLOGY AND GOVERNING THESIS The Mamluk century was a process of Indian-centred state formation
02	SOURCE AND METHOD MATRIX: TEXT, MATERIAL EVIDENCE AND SILENCE Technically, Source and method matrix: text, material evidence and
03	MILITARY SLAVERY, MANUMISSION AND ELITE HOUSEHOLD NETWORKS The institution solved a ruler's recruitment problem by creating
04	GHURID LEGACY AND THE FOUNDATION CHALLENGE AFTER 1206 Delhi had been a Ghurid base earlier, Alauk was enthroned at Lahore,
05	QUTB AL-DIN AIBAK: AUTHORITY, CAMPAIGNS, LAHORE-DELHI AND LIMITS Aram Shah's relationship to him is uncertain; advanced Satish
06	ILTUTMISH I: ACCESSION, ARAM SHAH, YILDIZ AND QUBACHA The exam-safe statement is that Lahore's Turkish army raised Aram,
07	ILTUTMISH II: MONGOLS, BENGAL, RAJPUT FRONTIERS AND REGIONAL LIMITS INTERPRETATION: Bengal demonstrates suzerainty without
08	ILTUTMISH III: IQTA, COINAGE, CALIPHAL INVESTITURE AND DELHI Later sultans could rule without meaningful caliphal enforcement; the
09	SUCCESSION CRISIS: RUKNUDDIN, SHAH TURKAN AND THE UNSTABLE DECADE The crisis was a failure of institutionalised succession and elite
10	RAZIYA: GENDER, OFFICE, NOBILITY AND SOURCE CRITICISM They were defeated; Raziya was killed during flight in 1240
11	CHHALGANI, LATER RULERS, NASIRUDDIN MAHMUD AND BALBAN'S RISE Balban's rise shows that the Chhalgani problem was not simply
12	BALBAN I: KINGSHIP IDEOLOGY, COURT RITUAL AND NOBLE CONTROL Court ritual was not decorative excess; it was a technology for
13	BALBAN II: ADMINISTRATION, JUSTICE, ARMY AND LAW/ORDER They prove the political ideal and possible enforcement; not equal
14	BALBAN III: MONGOL FRONTIER, BENGAL REBELLION, SUCCESS AND LIMIT Balban was a successful defensive consolidation; not a great territorial
15	STATE INSTITUTIONS: SULTAN, NOBILITY, OFFICES, IQTA, ARMY, JUSTICE AND Technically, State institutions: sultan, nobility, offices, iqta, army,
16	SOCIAL, ECONOMIC AND CULTURAL CHANGE: CITIES, PERSIANATE COURT AND INDIAN Turkic and Iqta often combined; Indian-Muslim such as Balban
17	ARCHITECTURE: QUTB COMPLEX, AJMER, SULTAN GHARI AND BALBAN'S TOMB Technically, Architecture: Qutb complex, Ajmer, Sultan Ghari and
18	NATURE OF THE EARLY SULTANATE: CENTRALISATION VERSUS NEGOTIATED 1015/1016/1017/1020s. The Sultanate was consolidated in 1016 and again
19	DECLINE OF THE MAMLUK LINE AND THE KHALJI TRANSITION The Khaljis inherited and expanded a state whose core institutions
20	HISTORIOGRAPHY, TERMINOLOGY, TIMELINE AND ANSWER-WRITING TOOLKIT Technically, Historiography, terminology, timeline and answer-writing
21	BOUNDED LIVE LINKAGE Technically, Bounded live linkage is analysed by relating UNESCO's

Original deterministic study visual; labels are explanatory, not textual quotations.

Source order: repository knowledge -> official current linkage -> clearly marked analysis. No fabricated PYQs or statistics.

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Foundation of the Delhi Sultanate: The Slave (Mamluk) Dynasty - Complete Topic Package

BASIC MCQS / REMEDIATION

Hard MCQ 01

Question: Which description of the Mamluk institution is most accurate?

- A. A trained military-household recruitment system in which elite slaves could be manumitted and rise to command or sovereignty.
- B. A hereditary caste in which no member could change legal status.
- C. A plantation labour system imposed on all Sultanate peasants.
- D. A modern cabinet of forty ministers.

Answer: A - A trained military-household recruitment system in which elite slaves could be manumitted and rise to command or sovereignty.

Explanation: It combined legal dependence, household training, patronage and mobility; manumission was necessary before sovereign rule.

Why the distractors fail: Each wrong option confuses chronology, institution, source status, territorial reach or a necessary qualification.

Hard MCQ 02

Question: What most clearly separates conquest after Tarain from consolidation of the Sultanate?

- A. The existence of a mosque at Delhi.
- B. Repeated control of forts, revenue, succession, frontiers and provincial obedience after the battlefield opening.
- C. The use of cavalry in 1192 alone.
- D. The death of every Rajput chief after one battle.

Answer: B - Repeated control of forts, revenue, succession, frontiers and provincial obedience after the battlefield opening.

Explanation: A battle opened territory; consolidation required institutions and repeated enforcement.

Why the distractors fail: Each wrong option confuses chronology, institution, source status, territorial reach or a necessary qualification.

Hard MCQ 03

Question: Which source is closest in time to Raziya and the early Balban period?

- A. Abul Fazl's Ain-i Akbari.
- B. Barani's Fatawa-i Jahandari.
- C. Minhaj-us-Siraj's Tabaqat-i Nasiri.
- D. Ferishta's later history.

Answer: C - Minhaj-us-Siraj's Tabaqat-i Nasiri.

Explanation: Minhaj completed his work around 1260 and lived within the political world he described.

Why the distractors fail: Each wrong option confuses chronology, institution, source status, territorial reach or a necessary qualification.

Hard MCQ 04

Question: Why must Barani's account of Balban be used cautiously?

- A. His work contains no discussion of nobles.
- B. He wrote before Aibak and knew nothing of Delhi.
- C. He was an archaeological excavator rather than a writer.
- D. He wrote later and combined political history with aristocratic, normative judgements about hierarchy and kingship.

Answer: D - He wrote later and combined political history with aristocratic, normative judgements about hierarchy and kingship.

Explanation: Barani is indispensable but chronologically later and ideologically invested.

Why the distractors fail: Each wrong option confuses chronology, institution, source status, territorial reach or a necessary qualification.

Hard MCQ 05

Question: What was Aibak's strongest independent contribution?

- A. He preserved political continuity and separation from Ghazni after 1206.
- B. He conquered the whole Deccan.
- C. He permanently subdued Bengal and Gujarat.
- D. He created the mansabdari system.

Answer: A - He preserved political continuity and separation from Ghazni after 1206.

Explanation: His short reign secured continuity; comprehensive consolidation came under Iltutmish.

Why the distractors fail: Each wrong option confuses chronology, institution, source status, territorial reach or a necessary qualification.

Hard MCQ 06

Question: Which statement about Aram Shah is safest?

- A. He defeated Iltutmish and ruled for decades.
- B. He was raised by Lahore's amirs, his relationship to Aibak is uncertain, and Iltutmish defeated him.
- C. He was a Khalji governor of Bengal.
- D. He was certainly Aibak's eldest biological son and uncontested heir.

Answer: B - He was raised by Lahore's amirs, his relationship to Aibak is uncertain, and Iltutmish defeated him.

Explanation: The advanced source questions the common son-of-Aibak claim.

Why the distractors fail: Each wrong option confuses chronology, institution, source status, territorial reach or a necessary qualification.

Hard MCQ 07

Question: Iltutmish's victory over Yildiz chiefly removed which problem?

- A. A Chola naval attack.
- B. A Portuguese blockade.
- C. A rival claim that Ghazni's Ghurid successor possessed senior authority over the Indian conquests.
- D. A Bengal peasant rebellion.

Answer: C - A rival claim that Ghazni's Ghurid successor possessed senior authority over the Indian conquests.

Explanation: Yildiz's claim was about Ghurid succession and Punjab-Delhi hierarchy.

Why the distractors fail: Each wrong option confuses chronology, institution, source status, territorial reach or a necessary qualification.

Hard MCQ 08

Question: Why did Iltutmish delay decisive action against Qubacha?

- A. Qubacha ruled from Bengal.
- B. He recognised Qubacha as caliph.
- C. He lacked any interest in the Indus.
- D. He sequenced threats and waited until Delhi, Punjab conditions and the Mongol-Khwarazm crisis made action safer.

Answer: D - He sequenced threats and waited until Delhi, Punjab conditions and the Mongol-Khwarazm crisis made action safer.

Explanation: Strategic patience is central to Iltutmish's consolidation.

Why the distractors fail: Each wrong option confuses chronology, institution, source status, territorial reach or a necessary qualification.

Hard MCQ 09

Question: What was Iltutmish's response to Jalaluddin Mangbarani in 1221?

- A. He avoided an alliance that could draw Delhi into direct war with Chinggis Khan.
- B. He surrendered Delhi to the Khwarazmians.
- C. He joined Mangbarani and defeated Chinggis near Delhi.
- D. He marched to conquer Mongolia.

Answer: A - He avoided an alliance that could draw Delhi into direct war with Chinggis Khan.

Explanation: The choice was survival diplomacy, not a military victory.

Why the distractors fail: Each wrong option confuses chronology, institution, source status, territorial reach or a necessary qualification.

Hard MCQ 10

Question: Which is the best interpretation of Iltutmish's Bengal policy?

- A. Bengal was governed directly by Yildiz.
- B. Repeated expeditions produced intermittent suzerainty, while distance and autonomous governors prevented continuous control.
- C. Bengal became a fully audited Delhi province after one battle.
- D. Delhi never claimed Bengal at all.

Answer: B - Repeated expeditions produced intermittent suzerainty, while distance and autonomous governors prevented continuous control.

Explanation: Iwaz's submission, rebellion and later interventions show fluctuating authority.

Why the distractors fail: Each wrong option confuses chronology, institution, source status, territorial reach or a necessary qualification.

Hard MCQ 11

Question: What did caliphal investiture in 1229 do?

- A. It made Baghdad administer Delhi's revenue.
- B. It abolished all noble opposition.
- C. It enhanced Iltutmish's symbolic legitimacy by recognising an accomplished fact.
- D. It supplied the army that defeated Yildiz.

Answer: C - It enhanced Iltutmish's symbolic legitimacy by recognising an accomplished fact.

Explanation: Investiture mattered morally and diplomatically, not as operational sovereignty.

Why the distractors fail: Each wrong option confuses chronology, institution, source status, territorial reach or a necessary qualification.

Hard MCQ 12

Question: Which statement about Iltutmish and iqta is correct?

- A. He made all iqtas permanently hereditary.
- B. He replaced every iqta with private freehold.
- C. He introduced Mughal mansabs.
- D. He adapted and regularised an older revenue-service institution; he did not invent it or convert it into hereditary property.

Answer: D - He adapted and regularised an older revenue-service institution; he did not invent it or convert it into hereditary property.

Explanation: Iqta had West Asian antecedents and remained a state assignment in principle.

Why the distractors fail: Each wrong option confuses chronology, institution, source status, territorial reach or a necessary qualification.

Hard MCQ 13

Question: What did the silver tanka and copper jital most directly support?

- A. Sovereign titlature, taxation, payment and market exchange within an increasingly Delhi-centred system.
- B. The abolition of barter across India.
- C. Caliphal taxation from Baghdad.
- D. Universal cash wages for every cultivator.

Answer: A - Sovereign titlature, taxation, payment and market exchange within an increasingly Delhi-centred system.

Explanation: Currency strengthened state and market routines, but monetisation remained uneven.

Why the distractors fail: Each wrong option confuses chronology, institution, source status, territorial reach or a necessary qualification.

Hard MCQ 14

Question: Why is Delhi's rise under Iltutmish more than a capital-change fact?

- A. It meant Lahore and Multan ceased to exist.
- B. It joined sustained royal presence, administration, migration, building, minting and scholarly-religious networks.
- C. It ended Mongol pressure permanently.
- D. It proved the countryside was uniformly governed.

Answer: B - It joined sustained royal presence, administration, migration, building, minting and scholarly-religious networks.

Explanation: Delhi became a dense node within a larger network.

Why the distractors fail: Each wrong option confuses chronology, institution, source status, territorial reach or a necessary qualification.

Hard MCQ 15

Question: What caused the post-1236 succession crisis most fundamentally?

- A. A Portuguese invasion.
- B. The abolition of cavalry.
- C. No settled succession mechanism and a struggle over whether crown or noble factions controlled office, iqta and force.
- D. The end of Persian as court language.

Answer: C - No settled succession mechanism and a struggle over whether crown or noble factions controlled office, iqta and force.

Explanation: Personal authority had not become a durable transfer rule.

Why the distractors fail: Each wrong option confuses chronology, institution, source status, territorial reach or a necessary qualification.

Hard MCQ 16

Question: What is the safest description of the Chihalgani?

- A. Raziya's group of forty women guards.
- B. A peasant assembly of forty villages.
- C. A Mughal artillery department.
- D. A later label for Iltutmish's powerful elite slave-officer network, not a literal fixed cabinet of forty.

Answer: D - A later label for Iltutmish's powerful elite slave-officer network, not a literal fixed cabinet of forty.

Explanation: Barani's number is not a reliable organisational roster.

Why the distractors fail: Each wrong option confuses chronology, institution, source status, territorial reach or a necessary qualification.

Hard MCQ 17

Question: How did Raziya initially strengthen her accession?

- A. She combined Iltutmish's nomination with urban support in Delhi and division of the opposing elite.
- B. She inherited an uncontested male primogeniture rule.
- C. She received a papal decree.
- D. She conquered Ghazni before entering Delhi.

Answer: A - She combined Iltutmish's nomination with urban support in Delhi and division of the opposing elite.

Explanation: Her rise required both dynastic claim and political mobilisation.

Why the distractors fail: Each wrong option confuses chronology, institution, source status, territorial reach or a necessary qualification.

Hard MCQ 18

Question: Why was Yaqut's office politically sensitive?

- A. He commanded the Portuguese navy.
- B. As amir-i-akhur he controlled royal stables and proximity to the sovereign, challenging Turkish monopoly over strategic access.
- C. He collected all Bengal land revenue.
- D. He was caliph of Baghdad.

Answer: B - As amir-i-akhur he controlled royal stables and proximity to the sovereign, challenging Turkish monopoly over strategic access.

Explanation: The institutional office matters more than romance.

Why the distractors fail: Each wrong option confuses chronology, institution, source status, territorial reach or a necessary qualification.

Hard MCQ 19

Question: Which claim about Raziya and Yaqut lacks contemporary support?

- A. That Turkish nobles resented his elevation.
- B. That he held the royal-stable office.
- C. That a romantic intimacy was the decisive cause of her fall.
- D. That he was killed during the rebellion.

Answer: C - That a romantic intimacy was the decisive cause of her fall.

Explanation: Later romance should not replace office, faction and gender analysis.

Why the distractors fail: Each wrong option confuses chronology, institution, source status, territorial reach or a necessary qualification.

Hard MCQ 20

Question: Which factor best completes a balanced explanation of Raziya's fall?

- A. Yaqut alone controlled all policy.
- B. Gender alone explains every event.
- C. Delhi's population unanimously opposed her from the start.
- D. Gendered legitimacy interacted with noble faction, provincial force, strategic office and coalition failure.

Answer: D - Gendered legitimacy interacted with noble faction, provincial force, strategic office and coalition failure.

Explanation: A multi-causal institutional explanation is required.

Why the distractors fail: Each wrong option confuses chronology, institution, source status, territorial reach or a necessary qualification.

Hard MCQ 21

Question: What did the repeated deposition of rulers after Raziya show?

- A. Hereditary legitimacy remained useful, but effective monarchy depended on control of nobles, offices and troops.
- B. The caliph directly selected every sultan.
- C. All provinces became independent permanently.
- D. Delhi had no political institutions.

Answer: A - Hereditary legitimacy remained useful, but effective monarchy depended on control of nobles, offices and troops.

Explanation: Dynastic title and operational power diverged.

Why the distractors fail: Each wrong option confuses chronology, institution, source status, territorial reach or a necessary qualification.

Hard MCQ 22

Question: Which statement about Nasiruddin Mahmud is most defensible?

- A. He never issued or approved a royal act.
- B. Pious withdrawal is a strong literary image, but Balban's dominance was real, contested and not uninterrupted.
- C. He personally created Alauddin's market system.
- D. He ruled only one year.

Answer: B - Pious withdrawal is a strong literary image, but Balban's dominance was real, contested and not uninterrupted.

Explanation: Balban was removed in 1253, proving that court politics remained active.

Why the distractors fail: Each wrong option confuses chronology, institution, source status, territorial reach or a necessary qualification.

Hard MCQ 23

Question: Why is Minhaj's hostility to Raihan source-critically important?

- A. Minhaj was Raihan's son.
- B. Raihan wrote the Tabaqat.
- C. Minhaj lost office under Raihan, so institutional self-interest may shape blame.
- D. Minhaj lived two centuries before Raihan.

Answer: C - Minhaj lost office under Raihan, so institutional self-interest may shape blame.

Explanation: Authorial position must be assessed before accepting motive.

Why the distractors fail: Each wrong option confuses chronology, institution, source status, territorial reach or a necessary qualification.

Hard MCQ 24

Question: What was Balban's position before 1266?

- A. Portuguese governor of Goa.
- B. Caliph at Baghdad.
- C. Independent ruler of Bengal.
- D. A powerful naib and kingmaker whose supremacy was periodically challenged by other nobles.

Answer: D - A powerful naib and kingmaker whose supremacy was periodically challenged by other nobles.

Explanation: His age begins politically before his formal accession.

Why the distractors fail: Each wrong option confuses chronology, institution, source status, territorial reach or a necessary qualification.

Hard MCQ 25

Question: What political function did Balban's court splendour serve?

- A. It transformed hierarchy and royal distance into visible awe over noble peers and visitors.
- B. It proved all Barani stories literal.
- C. It replaced the army entirely.
- D. It guaranteed hereditary succession.

Answer: A - It transformed hierarchy and royal distance into visible awe over noble peers and visitors.

Explanation: Ceremony was a mode of rule, not mere decoration.

Why the distractors fail: Each wrong option confuses chronology, institution, source status, territorial reach or a necessary qualification.

Hard MCQ 26

Question: How should zil-i-allah be interpreted?

- A. As abolition of Islam.
- B. As a Persianate-Islamic claim that exalted the sultan's delegated sacred prestige above nobles, not literal godhood.
- C. As a revenue tax.
- D. As election by a modern parliament.

Answer: B - As a Persianate-Islamic claim that exalted the sultan's delegated sacred prestige above nobles, not literal godhood.

Explanation: Political theology must be read in its medieval idiom.

Why the distractors fail: Each wrong option confuses chronology, institution, source status, territorial reach or a necessary qualification.

Hard MCQ 27

Question: Why were sijda and paibos controversial?

- A. They were silver coins.
- B. They were names of Mongol forts.
- C. They dramatised royal subordination but could conflict with theologians' view that prostration belonged to God.
- D. They were Rajput land taxes.

Answer: C - They dramatised royal subordination but could conflict with theologians' view that prostration belonged to God.

Explanation: The rituals joined political effect to religious debate.

Why the distractors fail: Each wrong option confuses chronology, institution, source status, territorial reach or a necessary qualification.

Hard MCQ 28

Question: What is wrong with quoting "blood and iron" as Balban's own slogan?

- A. It referred only to architecture.
- B. It was written on every Balban coin.
- C. It described Raziya's clothing.
- D. It is a later shorthand and must be tied to specific coercive policies rather than presented as a verified quotation.

Answer: D - It is a later shorthand and must be tied to specific coercive policies rather than presented as a verified quotation.

Explanation: Evidence discipline separates later labels from primary wording.

Why the distractors fail: Each wrong option confuses chronology, institution, source status, territorial reach or a necessary qualification.

Hard MCQ 29

Question: What was the main purpose of Balban's barids?

- A. Independent intelligence on officials, provincial events and oppression.
- B. Translation of Sanskrit texts.
- C. Management of royal stables.
- D. Collection of sea customs in Gujarat.

Answer: A - Independent intelligence on officials, provincial events and oppression.

Explanation: Information reduced the centre's dependence on governors' reports.

Why the distractors fail: Each wrong option confuses chronology, institution, source status, territorial reach or a necessary qualification.

Hard MCQ 30

Question: Why are Barani's justice stories useful but limited?

- A. They prove abolition of slavery.
- B. They illustrate an ideal and possible exemplary enforcement, not a complete record of equal justice.
- C. They are modern court judgements.
- D. They contain no named officials.

Answer: B - They illustrate an ideal and possible exemplary enforcement, not a complete record of equal justice.

Explanation: Narrative selection and moral purpose shape the evidence.

Why the distractors fail: Each wrong option confuses chronology, institution, source status, territorial reach or a necessary qualification.

Hard MCQ 31

Question: What did Balban's inquiry into old soldiers' village assignments attempt?

- A. To abolish the diwan-i-arz.
- B. To transfer every soldier to Bengal.
- C. To reconnect revenue assignment with actual military service and reduce unearned retention.
- D. To create hereditary zamindari.

Answer: C - To reconnect revenue assignment with actual military service and reduce unearned retention.

Explanation: The reform shows fiscal-military accountability and political resistance.

Why the distractors fail: Each wrong option confuses chronology, institution, source status, territorial reach or a necessary qualification.

Hard MCQ 32

Question: Which is the most balanced view of Balban's Mewat policy?

- A. It was a naval campaign.
- B. It permanently ended all regional resistance without coercion.
- C. It was a peaceful irrigation project only.
- D. It restored capital-route security through forest clearance, posts and settlement, but involved severe violence and displacement.

Answer: D - It restored capital-route security through forest clearance, posts and settlement, but involved severe violence and displacement.

Explanation: State capacity and social cost must both be stated.

Why the distractors fail: Each wrong option confuses chronology, institution, source status, territorial reach or a necessary qualification.

Hard MCQ 33

Question: Why did Balban avoid distant conquest?

- A. Mongol pressure required a royal reserve near Delhi and sustained frontier vigilance.
- B. He had no army.
- C. The caliph prohibited all campaigns.
- D. He was unaware of Malwa and Gujarat.

Answer: A - Mongol pressure required a royal reserve near Delhi and sustained frontier vigilance.

Explanation: Defensive consolidation ranked above expansion.

Why the distractors fail: Each wrong option confuses chronology, institution, source status, territorial reach or a necessary qualification.

Hard MCQ 34

Question: What was the practical frontier under much of Balban's period?

- A. The Oxus River under complete Delhi rule.
- B. A defensive zone focused around the Beas and forts such as Tabarhinda, Sunam and Samana, with Multan under pressure.
- C. The Narmada as a Mongol frontier.
- D. The Bay of Bengal coast.

Answer: B - A defensive zone focused around the Beas and forts such as Tabarhinda, Sunam and Samana, with Multan under pressure.

Explanation: Delhi did not securely recover all western Punjab.

Why the distractors fail: Each wrong option confuses chronology, institution, source status, territorial reach or a necessary qualification.

Hard MCQ 35

Question: What is the correct assessment of Hulegu-Balban diplomacy?

- A. It made Balban Hulegu's governor.
- B. It ended every Mongol incursion forever.
- C. It helped manage a frontier status quo while wider Mongol priorities and local raids continued.
- D. It transferred Baghdad to Delhi.

Answer: C - It helped manage a frontier status quo while wider Mongol priorities and local raids continued.

Explanation: Diplomacy complemented defence; it did not erase the threat.

Why the distractors fail: Each wrong option confuses chronology, institution, source status, territorial reach or a necessary qualification.

Hard MCQ 36

Question: Why was Prince Muhammad's death in 1285 especially important?

- A. It founded the Khalji dynasty immediately.
- B. It created the Qutb Minar.
- C. It ended Bengal's autonomy.
- D. It removed Balban's trained heir and exposed the succession weakness of his personal monarchy.

Answer: D - It removed Balban's trained heir and exposed the succession weakness of his personal monarchy.

Explanation: Frontier defence and dynastic failure converged.

Why the distractors fail: Each wrong option confuses chronology, institution, source status, territorial reach or a necessary qualification.

Hard MCQ 37

Question: What does Tughril's Bengal rebellion reveal?

- A. Remote governors could turn revenue, elephants, troops and distance into a rival sovereignty.
- B. Bengal was always directly audited.
- C. Balban never campaigned outside Delhi.
- D. The Mongols governed Lakhnauti.

Answer: A - Remote governors could turn revenue, elephants, troops and distance into a rival sovereignty.

Explanation: The rebellion demonstrates the limits of network control.

Why the distractors fail: Each wrong option confuses chronology, institution, source status, territorial reach or a necessary qualification.

Hard MCQ 38

Question: Why does Balban's final Bengal victory not prove permanent integration?

- A. The victory occurred under Akbar.
- B. Bughra Khan later preferred an autonomous Bengal and Delhi's command again weakened.
- C. Tughril became sultan of Delhi.
- D. Bengal disappeared as a region.

Answer: B - Bughra Khan later preferred an autonomous Bengal and Delhi's command again weakened.

Explanation: A campaign could restore submission without durable administration.

Why the distractors fail: Each wrong option confuses chronology, institution, source status, territorial reach or a necessary qualification.

Hard MCQ 39

Question: Which statement best defines iqta?

- A. A tax-free temple grant only.
- B. A modern district elected council.
- C. A transferable claim to collect state revenue for service and administration, subject in principle to audit and recall.
- D. Private hereditary ownership of land and peasants.

Answer: C - A transferable claim to collect state revenue for service and administration, subject in principle to audit and recall.

Explanation: Revenue assignment is not proprietary title.

Why the distractors fail: Each wrong option confuses chronology, institution, source status, territorial reach or a necessary qualification.

Hard MCQ 40

Question: How did local intermediaries affect Sultanate centralisation?

- A. They were abolished in 1206.
- B. They had no role outside trade.
- C. They existed only in Baghdad.
- D. They supplied knowledge, collection and coercive links, making central claims dependent on negotiated local power.

Answer: D - They supplied knowledge, collection and coercive links, making central claims dependent on negotiated local power.

Explanation: The apex could be centralised while implementation remained layered.

Why the distractors fail: Each wrong option confuses chronology, institution, source status, territorial reach or a necessary qualification.

Hard MCQ 41

Question: Which office handled state correspondence?

- A. Diwan-i-insha.
- B. Diwan-i-Kohi under Iltutmish.
- C. Amir-i-akhur.
- D. Mir Bakshi.

Answer: A - Diwan-i-insha.

Explanation: The insha was the chancery/correspondence department.

Why the distractors fail: Each wrong option confuses chronology, institution, source status, territorial reach or a necessary qualification.

Hard MCQ 42

Question: Which office is associated with military administration under the Sultanate?

- A. Sadr as cavalry commander.
- B. Diwan-i-arz under the ariz, while the sultan remained commander-in-chief.
- C. Kotwal as caliph.
- D. Mir Bakshi under Aibak.

Answer: B - Diwan-i-arz under the ariz, while the sultan remained commander-in-chief.

Explanation: Do not project the Mughal Mir Bakshi backward.

Why the distractors fail: Each wrong option confuses chronology, institution, source status, territorial reach or a necessary qualification.

Hard MCQ 43

Question: What is the safest meaning of "Persianate"?

- A. A synonym for Shia state.
- B. A biological Persian race ruling without Indian participation.
- C. A transregional Persian-language court and administrative culture that could include people of varied origins.
- D. A style limited to poetry.

Answer: C - A transregional Persian-language court and administrative culture that could include people of varied origins.

Explanation: Culture, language and political practice should not be reduced to ethnicity.

Why the distractors fail: Each wrong option confuses chronology, institution, source status, territorial reach or a necessary qualification.

Hard MCQ 44

Question: Which monument began under Aibak before his independent reign?

- A. Balban's tomb.
- B. Alai Darwaza.
- C. Tughlaqabad.
- D. Quwwat-ul-Islam mosque, begun in 1198 within the Ghurid conquest phase.

Answer: D - Quwwat-ul-Islam mosque, begun in 1198 within the Ghurid conquest phase.

Explanation: Chronology distinguishes Ghurid delegated patronage from post-1206 sovereignty.

Why the distractors fail: Each wrong option confuses chronology, institution, source status, territorial reach or a necessary qualification.

Hard MCQ 45

Question: What is the correct patronage sequence for Qutb Minar?

- A. Aibak laid the foundation and raised the first storey; Iltutmish added three; later rulers repaired or altered it.
- B. Raziya built all storeys in 1236.
- C. Alauddin completed it before Tarain.
- D. Balban built it after 1287.

Answer: A - Aibak laid the foundation and raised the first storey; Iltutmish added three; later rulers repaired or altered it.

Explanation: ASI inscriptions support a multi-ruler sequence.

Why the distractors fail: Each wrong option confuses chronology, institution, source status, territorial reach or a necessary qualification.

Hard MCQ 46

Question: How should temple material at Quwwat-ul-Islam be treated?

- A. As proof that no temple material was used.
- B. As evidence of conquest-era demolition/reuse, expediency, public claims and local craft, without reducing the whole monument to one slogan.
- C. As evidence that Aibak invented stone carving.
- D. As proof of purely harmonious borrowing.

Answer: B - As evidence of conquest-era demolition/reuse, expediency, public claims and local craft, without reducing the whole monument to one slogan.

Explanation: Facts of reuse and multiple historical meanings can coexist.

Why the distractors fail: Each wrong option confuses chronology, institution, source status, territorial reach or a necessary qualification.

Hard MCQ 47

Question: What is the safe claim for Balban's tomb?

- A. It was built by Iltutmish for Nasiruddin.
- B. It is India's first structure of any kind.
- C. The assigned source identifies its surviving arch as the first true arch in the Sultanate sequence; broader invention claims are unsafe.
- D. Its original dome survives intact.

Answer: C - The assigned source identifies its surviving arch as the first true arch in the Sultanate sequence; broader invention claims are unsafe.

Explanation: The claim concerns a surviving structural milestone, not the first awareness of arches.

Why the distractors fail: Each wrong option confuses chronology, institution, source status, territorial reach or a necessary qualification.

Hard MCQ 48

Question: What best describes Sultan Ghari?

- A. A palace built for Raziya.
- B. A Mongol fort at Multan.
- C. A Khalji market.
- D. An early royal mausoleum built by Iltutmish for his son Nasiruddin Mahmud, important in Delhi's funerary tradition.

Answer: D - An early royal mausoleum built by Iltutmish for his son Nasiruddin Mahmud, important in Delhi's funerary tradition.

Explanation: It marks early tomb patronage and should not be confused with Sultan Nasiruddin's later reign.

Why the distractors fail: Each wrong option confuses chronology, institution, source status, territorial reach or a necessary qualification.

Remedial MCQ 49

Question: Which formula corrects the "Aibak founded everything" error?

- A. Aibak preserved independent continuity; Iltutmish carried out the principal multi-front consolidation.
- B. Iltutmish ruled before Tarain.
- C. Aibak and Iltutmish were one ruler.
- D. Aibak completed Bengal, Sind and Mongol defence.

Answer: A - Aibak preserved independent continuity; Iltutmish carried out the principal multi-front consolidation.

Explanation: Separate start from consolidation.

Why the distractors fail: Each wrong option confuses chronology, institution, source status, territorial reach or a necessary qualification.

Remedial target: Correct the named misconception before returning to the comparative and source-based questions.

Remedial MCQ 50

Question: Which statement corrects the "iqta equals feudal estate" error?

- A. Iqta conveyed absolute hereditary ownership.
- B. Iqta was a revocable revenue-service assignment whose enforcement and transfer varied.
- C. Iqta abolished the state's revenue claim.
- D. Iqta was a village council.

Answer: B - Iqta was a revocable revenue-service assignment whose enforcement and transfer varied.

Explanation: Assignment is not property.

Why the distractors fail: Each wrong option confuses chronology, institution, source status, territorial reach or a necessary qualification.

Remedial target: Correct the named misconception before returning to the comparative and source-based questions.

Remedial MCQ 51

Question: Which statement corrects the "Forty equals forty ministers" error?

- A. It was Raziya's women's council.
- B. It was a tax of forty tankas.
- C. Chihalgani was Barani's later label for an elite network; exact membership and unity were fluid.
- D. Exactly forty names and portfolios survive.

Answer: C - Chihalgani was Barani's later label for an elite network; exact membership and unity were fluid.

Explanation: Treat the term cautiously.

Why the distractors fail: Each wrong option confuses chronology, institution, source status, territorial reach or a necessary qualification.

Remedial target: Correct the named misconception before returning to the comparative and source-based questions.

Remedial MCQ 52

Question: Which statement corrects the Raziya romance error?

- A. Minhaj accused her of a proven affair.
- B. She never led an army.
- C. Yaqut alone caused every rebellion.
- D. Her fall arose from gendered legitimacy, office, provincial military power and noble faction; romance is unsupported.

Answer: D - Her fall arose from gendered legitimacy, office, provincial military power and noble faction; romance is unsupported.

Explanation: Institutions and source criticism replace legend.

Why the distractors fail: Each wrong option confuses chronology, institution, source status, territorial reach or a necessary qualification.

Remedial target: Correct the named misconception before returning to the comparative and source-based questions.

Remedial MCQ 53

Question: Which statement corrects the caliphate error?

- A. Investiture enhanced legitimacy after consolidation but gave Baghdad no effective administration over Delhi.
- B. The investiture defeated Qubacha militarily.
- C. Iltutmish became a provincial governor of Baghdad.
- D. The caliph appointed every muqti.

Answer: A - Investiture enhanced legitimacy after consolidation but gave Baghdad no effective administration over Delhi.

Explanation: Recognition is not operational rule.

Why the distractors fail: Each wrong option confuses chronology, institution, source status, territorial reach or a necessary qualification.

Remedial target: Correct the named misconception before returning to the comparative and source-based questions.

Remedial MCQ 54

Question: Which statement corrects the "blood and iron quotation" error?

- A. Apply it only to court architecture.
- B. Use it only as modern shorthand for named coercive measures and state-security policy.
- C. Use it to describe Iltutmish's coins.
- D. Print it as Balban's verified slogan.

Answer: B - Use it only as modern shorthand for named coercive measures and state-security policy.

Explanation: Do not invent quotations.

Why the distractors fail: Each wrong option confuses chronology, institution, source status, territorial reach or a necessary qualification.

Remedial target: Correct the named misconception before returning to the comparative and source-based questions.

Remedial MCQ 55

Question: Which statement corrects the Mongol-defence error?

- A. The frontier was always the Indus under Delhi.
- B. No Mongol reached Lahore before Alauddin.
- C. Balban contained danger to the core but did not permanently recover all western Punjab.
- D. Balban conquered Mongolia.

Answer: C - Balban contained danger to the core but did not permanently recover all western Punjab.

Explanation: Success was defensive and qualified.

Why the distractors fail: Each wrong option confuses chronology, institution, source status, territorial reach or a necessary qualification.

Remedial target: Correct the named misconception before returning to the comparative and source-based questions.

Remedial MCQ 56

Question: Which statement corrects the Bengal error?

- A. No Lakhnauti governor rebelled.
- B. Bengal was continuously direct khalisa land.
- C. Bughra Khan became a loyal Delhi bureaucrat.
- D. Delhi's authority was intermittent; repeated governors and Balban's victory did not prevent later autonomy.

Answer: D - Delhi's authority was intermittent; repeated governors and Balban's victory did not prevent later autonomy.

Explanation: Distance and regional resources mattered.

Why the distractors fail: Each wrong option confuses chronology, institution, source status, territorial reach or a necessary qualification.

Remedial target: Correct the named misconception before returning to the comparative and source-based questions.

Remedial MCQ 57

Question: Which statement corrects the architecture "pure synthesis" error?

- A. Early monuments combine conquest, spolia, Indian labour, new plans and technical experimentation.
- B. There was no destruction or appropriation.
- C. Every arch was scientifically true from 1198.
- D. There was no local craft contribution.

Answer: A - Early monuments combine conquest, spolia, Indian labour, new plans and technical experimentation.

Explanation: Name the process rather than use a celebratory label.

Why the distractors fail: Each wrong option confuses chronology, institution, source status, territorial reach or a necessary qualification.

Remedial target: Correct the named misconception before returning to the comparative and source-based questions.

Remedial MCQ 58

Question: Which statement corrects the true-arch error?

- A. Quwwat used only mature true arches.
- B. Arches were known earlier; Balban's tomb is important for the first surviving true arch claimed in the assigned Sultanate sequence.
- C. Alai Darwaza predates Aibak.
- D. Balban invented the arch globally.

Answer: B - Arches were known earlier; Balban's tomb is important for the first surviving true arch claimed in the assigned Sultanate sequence.

Explanation: Distinguish knowledge, survival and mature technique.

Why the distractors fail: Each wrong option confuses chronology, institution, source status, territorial reach or a necessary qualification.

Remedial target: Correct the named misconception before returning to the comparative and source-based questions.

Remedial MCQ 59

Question: Which statement corrects the state-character error?

- A. It had no central institutions.
- B. It was a modern unitary bureaucracy.
- C. The Sultanate was centralised at the apex but relied on provincial and local networks for implementation.
- D. Every village was governed directly from Delhi.

Answer: C - The Sultanate was centralised at the apex but relied on provincial and local networks for implementation.

Explanation: Centre and negotiated periphery coexisted.

Why the distractors fail: Each wrong option confuses chronology, institution, source status, territorial reach or a necessary qualification.

Remedial target: Correct the named misconception before returning to the comparative and source-based questions.

Remedial MCQ 60

Question: Which statement corrects the dynastic-decline error?

- A. The Khaljis abolished iqta and Persian administration immediately.
- B. The Delhi Sultanate ended permanently in 1290.
- C. Balban founded the Mughal Empire.
- D. The Mamluk line ended in 1290, but its Delhi-centred institutions continued and enabled Khalji expansion.

Answer: D - The Mamluk line ended in 1290, but its Delhi-centred institutions continued and enabled Khalji expansion.

Explanation: Dynastic change was not state disappearance.

Why the distractors fail: Each wrong option confuses chronology, institution, source status, territorial reach or a necessary qualification.

Remedial target: Correct the named misconception before returning to the comparative and source-based questions.

PYQS AND ANSWER PRACTICE

PYQ 01 - 2019 Prelims GS-I Q12: revenue administration

Verified question: Consider the following statements:

1. In the revenue administration of Delhi Sultanate, the in-charge of revenue collection was known as "Amil".
2. The Iqta system of Sultans of Delhi was an ancient indigenous institution.
3. The office of "Mir Bakshi" came into existence during the reign of Khalji Sultans of Delhi.

Which of the statements given above is/are correct?

- A. 1 only
- B. 1 and 2 only
- C. 3 only
- D. 1, 2 and 3

INFERRED ANSWER - NOT OFFICIALLY VERIFIED LOCALLY: A, 1 only. Confidence: high.

Solved explanation

- Statement 1 is correct: *amil* was a revenue-collection official.
- Statement 2 is incorrect: iqta had West and Central Asian antecedents. Under Delhi it became an adapted fiscal-military assignment; it was not an ancient indigenous institution.
- Statement 3 is incorrect: *Mir Bakshi* belongs to the Mughal administrative order. The Sultanate military department was associated with the *ariz* and *diwan-i-arz*.
- Topic significance: The question tests whether institutions are placed in the correct polity and whether iqta is mistaken for an indigenous hereditary land system.

Why this earns marks: It evaluates every statement independently, distinguishes institutional origin from Indian adaptation and avoids projecting a Mughal office backward.

PYQ 02 - 2022 Prelims GS-I Q57: Mongol invasions

Verified question: With reference to Indian history, consider the following statements:

1. The first Mongol invasion of India happened during the reign of Jalal-ud-din Khalji.
2. During the reign of Ala-ud-din Khalji, one Mongol assault marched up to Delhi and besieged the city.
3. Muhammad-bin-Tughlaq temporarily lost portions of north-west of his kingdom to Mongols.

Which of the statements given above is/are correct?

- A. 1 and 2
- B. 2 only

- C. 1 and 3
- D. 3 only

INFERRED ANSWER - NOT OFFICIALLY VERIFIED LOCALLY: B, 2 only. Confidence: high.

Solved explanation

- Statement 1 is incorrect: Mongol pressure reached the Indus in Iltutmish's reign in 1221 with Chinggis Khan's pursuit of Jalaluddin Mangbarani; Lahore was sacked in 1241, well before Jalaluddin Khalji.
- Statement 2 is correct: major Mongol assaults reached Delhi in Alauddin Khalji's reign, including the 1303 crisis associated with Siri.
- Statement 3 is incorrect in the wording used: Muhammad bin Tughlaq faced Mongol diplomacy and frontier issues, but the stated temporary loss is not the standard event.
- Topic significance: The Mamluk period established the strategic problem and the Beas-frontier response later inherited by the Khaljis.

Why this earns marks: It anchors each statement to ruler and date, separates first pressure from later siege and avoids letting a familiar Tughlaq name validate an unsupported statement.

PYQ 03 - 2020 GS-I Mains: Persian literary sources

Verified question: "Persian literary sources of medieval India reflect the spirit of the age." Comment. (15 marks, 250 words)

Model answer

- **Direct thesis:** Persian works reflect the age because their genres record conquest, court hierarchy, political ethics, urban culture and administrative aspiration; yet they reflect an elite courtly age more fully than the whole population.
- **Early conquest and legitimacy:** Hasan Nizami's *Taj-ul-Ma'asir* celebrates Ghurid-Aibak success in ornate panegyric. Its language reveals the ideology of victory and new court patronage, although literary display and selective chronology limit factual extraction.
- **Dynastic and institutional world:** Minhaj-us-Siraj's *Tabaqat-i Nasiri* preserves the Ghurid-Mamluk sequence, Bakhtiyar's career, Iltutmish's consolidation and Raziya's politics. Minhaj's praise of Raziya's qualities followed by a gendered judgement exposes both the possibility of female sovereignty and clerical-patriarchal assumptions.
- **Kingship and aristocracy:** Barani's later *Tarikh-i Firuz Shahi* depicts the Chihalgani, Balban's court ritual, noble exclusivity, intelligence and justice. His *Fatawa-i Jahandari* reveals an aristocratic normative order, but his hostility to low-born advancement and chronological distance require corroboration.
- **Military-political advice:** Fakhr-i Mudabbir's writing illuminates ideals of army, hierarchy and Persianate statecraft. Prescriptive ideals cannot be equated with uniform practice.
- **Silences and checks:** These texts privilege male elites, capitals, war and office. Coins, inscriptions, Qutb architecture, local traditions and regional evidence are needed for currency, patronage, craft, non-elite life and implementation.
- **Conclusion:** Persian literary sources do reflect the spirit of medieval court and state formation, but only a source-critical, comparative reading converts that spirit into social history.

Why this earns marks: It comments rather than lists, uses four named authors and works, links evidence to political, gender and social meaning, and explicitly qualifies patronage and silence.

PYQ search conclusion

- No direct standalone GS Mains question devoted only to Aibak, Iltutmish, Raziya or Balban was located in the bounded repository 2018-2025 paper/routing set.
- The package uses two verified Prelims routes and one verified Mains source question with genuine topic ownership; no coaching prompt is relabelled as a UPSC PYQ.

Mains 10M-1 - Meaning of the Mamluk institution

Question: Explain why the term Slave or Mamluk dynasty requires careful use. (10 marks, 150 words)

Model answer

- Direct thesis: The label is useful for a thirteenth-century ruling phase whose leading figures emerged from elite military slavery, but it becomes misleading if it suggests plantation slavery, permanent legal bondage or a single hereditary line.
- Claim -> evidence -> significance -> limit: Aibak was Muizz al-Din's trained mamluk commander and received manumission before sovereign recognition. This shows social mobility through household service, although royal favour did not remove later rivalry.
- Claim -> evidence -> significance -> limit: Iltutmish had been Aibak's mamluk and son-in-law; Balban was bought by Iltutmish and rose through office. Household ties supplied trained cadres, yet these men built autonomous followings and dynasties.
- Claim -> evidence -> significance -> limit: Islamic political theory required a sovereign to be free. Manumission therefore changed legal status; "slave king" is not a description of a reigning ruler's continuing bondage.
- Claim -> evidence -> significance -> limit: Succession passed through Aram Shah, Iltutmish's descendants and Balban's house, not one bloodline. "Dynasty" is a chronological convenience.
- Conclusion: The safest phrase is an early Delhi Sultanate shaped by military-slave household networks, manumission and service mobility.

Why this earns marks: It defines the contested term, uses three ruler-based evidence chains, distinguishes legal status from institutional origin and ends with an exam-safe formulation.

Mains 10M-2 - Iltutmish as consolidator

Question: Why is Iltutmish regarded as the principal consolidator of the Delhi Sultanate? (10 marks, 150 words)

Model answer

- Direct thesis: Iltutmish converted Aibak's fragile Ghurid inheritance into an independent, defensible and Delhi-centred polity through sequenced military, fiscal and symbolic measures.
- Claim -> evidence -> significance -> limit: He defeated Aram Shah and resistant Turkish officers, securing the capital core. This settled immediate succession, though noble faction survived.
- Claim -> evidence -> significance -> limit: He eliminated Yildiz's senior claim and Qubacha's Multan-Uch-Sind state by 1228. Delhi gained strategic autonomy, but later Punjab control remained exposed.
- Claim -> evidence -> significance -> limit: In 1221 he avoided alliance with Mangbarani against Chinggis Khan. Prudence preserved the weak state; it was not a military victory.
- Claim -> evidence -> significance -> limit: Repeated Bengal campaigns and fort recovery at Bayana, Gwalior and Ranthambhor widened suzerainty. Gujarat failure and Bengal rebellion show uneven reach.
- Claim -> evidence -> significance -> limit: Iqta discipline, tanka-jital currency, Delhi patronage and 1229 caliphal investiture strengthened institutions and legitimacy without being invented from nothing.
- Conclusion: He was "real founder" in consolidation, not creator of uniform rule.

Why this earns marks: It covers territorial, diplomatic, fiscal, monetary, capital and legitimacy dimensions with precise qualifications proportional to ten marks.

Mains 10M-3 - Raziya's fall

Question: Raziya's fall cannot be explained by gender alone. Explain. (10 marks, 150 words)

Model answer

- Direct thesis: Gender structured Raziya's vulnerability, but her fall resulted from the interaction of gendered legitimacy, noble corporate interests, strategic office and provincial military power.
- Claim -> evidence -> significance -> limit: Iltutmish nominated her over surviving sons and Minhaj praised her prudence, justice and warfare. Ability was recognised, but nomination did not bind the nobles.

- Claim -> evidence -> significance -> limit: She appeared unveiled, held court and led armies. Visible sovereignty challenged gender expectations; it also expressed direct monarchy.
- Claim -> evidence -> significance -> limit: Yaqut's appointment as amir-i-akhur threatened Turkish monopoly over a strategic office close to the ruler. Contemporary evidence does not support a romance.
- Claim -> evidence -> significance -> limit: Lahore and Tabarhinda governors rebelled within a wider Delhi faction. Her coalition lacked the durable armed household needed to survive coordinated opposition.
- Conclusion: Gender gave opponents a language of exclusion, while office, faction and military resources turned prejudice into deposition.

Why this earns marks: It answers the "not alone" demand, uses Iltutmish, Minhaj, Yaqut and provincial rebellions as evidence, and rejects unsupported romance.

Mains 15M-1 - Crown and Chihalgani

Question: Examine the monarchy-nobility struggle under the Mamluks with reference to the Chihalgani. (15 marks, 250 words)

Model answer

- Direct thesis: The Chihalgani symbolises the paradox of military-slave state formation: Iltutmish's household officers strengthened the monarchy, but their accumulated iqta, commands and equality claims destabilised succession and enabled one of them, Balban, to destroy peer rule.
- Formation: Iltutmish promoted trained slave officers within a wider elite of free Turks and Tajik administrators. Household dependence supplied loyal service during consolidation. Yet office, marriage and provincial command created independent resources.
- Source caution: Barani later called them the "Corps of Forty." The advanced source identifies fewer than twenty-five and notes that they were not consistently united. The term denotes a prestige network, not a literal cabinet.
- Succession crisis: After 1236 governors and court officers enthroned or removed Ruknuddin, Raziya, Bahram and Masud. A naib-wazir-mustaufi combination briefly reduced the ruler, but factional conflict prevented stable oligarchy.
- Raziya: Her attempt at direct rule and Yaqut's elevation threatened Turkish strategic-office monopoly. Gender was instrumentalised within the larger crown-peer contest.
- Balban as naib: He rose from the same network, was removed in 1253, rebuilt alliances and returned. This proves that no corporate body possessed settled constitutional control.
- Balban as sultan: Court ritual, barids, punishment and elimination of rivals ended the claim that nobles were royal equals. However, narrow high-born ideology and personal coercion did not create durable succession.
- Conclusion: The struggle ended institutionally in favour of a stronger sultan, but dynastically remained unresolved, preparing both Balban's centralisation and the Khalji transition.

Why this earns marks: It defines the term cautiously, follows the struggle across four phases, links office and iqta to power, and balances institutional victory with dynastic failure.

Mains 15M-2 - Iqta as fiscal-military institution

Question: Discuss the iqta system under the early Delhi Sultanate and explain why it should not be equated with hereditary feudal property. (15 marks, 250 words)

Model answer

- Direct thesis: Iqta was a transferable assignment of state revenue linked to service and administration. It could create powerful territorial officers, but it did not legally grant private ownership of land, cultivators or a hereditary principality.
- Origin and adaptation: Iqta had West and Central Asian antecedents before Iltutmish. The Delhi rulers adapted it to Indian agrarian and local-revenue realities; calling it ancient indigenous or an invention of one sultan is inaccurate.
- Mechanism: The sultan assigned a tract to a muqti or wali, who collected authorised revenue, maintained troops and order, met expenses and in principle remitted surplus. Khalisa revenue remained more directly available to the

crown.

- Centralising logic: Transfer, audit and recall prevented permanent local roots and converted surplus into cavalry. Iltutmish used assignments to support consolidation; Balban's barids and inquiry into old soldier grants show the continuing concern with service-accountability.
- Limits in practice: Distance, weak rulers and armed followings let governors retain revenue or act independently. Qubacha's rival state, Bengal governors and Tughril demonstrate that a fiscal assignment could become a sovereignty base.
- Why not feudal property: Legal title remained with the state; assignment was conditional and transferable. European "feudalism" and later zamindari carry different property and juridical histories.
- Qualification: Procedures evolved, and evidence from later Sultanate administration cannot be projected unchanged onto the early thirteenth century.
- Conclusion: Iqta was simultaneously an instrument of central mobilisation and a recurrent source of provincial autonomy.

Why this earns marks: It explains origin, mechanism, centralising function, rebellion risk and comparative caution, with named Iltutmish-Balban-Bengal evidence.

Mains 15M-3 - Early Sultanate architecture

Question: Early Sultanate architecture was produced through conquest, reuse and technical adaptation rather than a simple story of either destruction or synthesis. Discuss. (15 marks, 250 words)

Model answer

- Direct thesis: The Qutb-Ajmer monuments record coercive appropriation and temple-material reuse, while also documenting Indian craft labour, new congregational forms and gradual mastery of arcuate construction. Both rupture and adaptation must be retained.
- Conquest and reuse: ASI records that Quwwat-ul-Islam's cloisters incorporated members from twenty-seven Hindu and Jaina temples, as stated in its entrance inscription. Adhai Din ka Jhonpra likewise occupies an earlier Sanskrit-college/temple context. This is evidence of conquest and appropriation, not neutral recycling.
- Expediency and claim: Reused pillars supplied material and skilled carving for rapid monumental assertion. Victory inscriptions and congregational plans transformed the political meaning of components; expediency does not erase ideology.
- Craft and form: Indian masons and stone-carvers executed the buildings. Local trabeate/corbelled methods and motifs coexisted with West Asian arch, screen, calligraphy and mosque planning. "Synthesis" is meaningful only when these specific processes are named.
- Technical sequence: Aibak began Qutb Minar and Iltutmish added major storeys. Iltutmish's tomb shows square-to-dome experimentation; Balban's tomb contains the first surviving true arch identified by the assigned source; Alai Darwaza later shows mature technique.
- Limits: Buildings have additions and repair phases; monuments represent elite patronage more than ordinary social experience. "First arch in India" is an overclaim because arches were known earlier.
- Conclusion: Early Sultanate architecture is best read as a conflict-laden laboratory where reused material, local skill and new political-religious forms produced a changing architectural language.

Why this earns marks: It names four monuments, uses ASI inscriptional evidence, distinguishes ideology from expediency and traces technical development with a precise true-arch caveat.

Mains 20M-1 - Nature of the early Sultanate

Question: Was the early Delhi Sultanate a centralised territorial state or a negotiated network of military power?

Analyse. (20 marks, 300 words)

Model answer

- Direct thesis: It was centralised in sovereign claim, capital institutions and fiscal-military aspiration, but negotiated and uneven in operation. The apparent alternatives describe different levels of the same state.
- Central apex: Aibak's separation from Ghazni and Iltutmish's defeat of Aram, Yildiz and Qubacha established independent sovereignty. The sultan distributed office and iqta, commanded the army, minted currency and claimed royal justice. Delhi's court, chancery and monumental programme made the apex visible.
- Institutional density: Wazir, ariz, insha, qazi-sadr functions, barids, khalisa and iqta differentiated central tasks. Iltutmish's tanka-jital and 1229 investiture strengthened fiscal and symbolic authority. The exact departmental form evolved and cannot be treated as a modern bureaucracy.
- Negotiated implementation: Muqtis, fort commanders, tributary rulers and local khuts, muqaddams, chiefs and accountants translated orders into revenue and force. An iqta was transferable in principle, but distance and armed followings enabled autonomy.
- Regional evidence: Bengal repeatedly submitted and rebelled; Iltutmish's Gujarat venture failed; Ranthambhor could be held indirectly; western Punjab was exposed to Mongols. Balban killed Tughril but Bughra Khan later detached Bengal.
- Social composition: The ruling elite was initially Turkic-Tajik and Persianate, yet the state relied on Indian Muslim officers, Hindu chiefs, soldiers, artisans and agrarian intermediaries. It was an institutional form of conquest, but not socially self-contained.
- Centralising turn: Balban's court ritual, spies, direct force, road security and iqta supervision increased royal capacity. His dependence on personal coercion, narrow high-born ideology and failed succession reveals the limit.
- Conceptual qualification: It was neither a modern unitary territorial state nor a formless confederacy. "Feudal" and "theocratic" labels require precise definitions.
- Conclusion: The best model is a hierarchical military-fiscal network: dense at Delhi and the upper doab, thinner and more negotiated toward Punjab, Bengal and Rajasthan.

Why this earns marks: It resolves the binary through level-of-analysis, uses institutions plus four regional tests, includes social composition and ends with a spatially graded verdict.

Mains 20M-2 - Balban's statecraft

Question: Critically evaluate Balban's kingship, internal policy and frontier strategy. (20 marks, 300 words)

Model answer

- Direct thesis: Balban restored royal authority and protected the Delhi core through ceremony, intelligence, coercive order and frontier caution; his success was defensive and institutional, while exclusion, brutality and failed succession limited durability.
- Kingship: As zil-i-Allah, Balban placed the sultan above noble peers. Sijda, paibos, ordered ranks, guards and austere conduct turned court performance into political hierarchy. Barani's later dramatic account conveys ideology but cannot be quoted uncritically.
- Nobility: Balban broke Chihalgani equality, removed rivals and denied power-sharing even to kin. He defended high-born Turkish status while monopolising authority. Barani's prejudice shapes the reported exclusion of low-born groups, and actual exceptions show incomplete enforcement.
- Justice and intelligence: Barids reported on governors; exemplary punishment of Bakbak and Haibat Khan asserted royal justice above noble privilege. These selected stories demonstrate an ideal and possible practice, not a universal judicial record.
- Law and order: Forest clearance, thanas and Afghan settlement around Delhi, the doab and Katehar reopened routes and strengthened revenue. The same operations involved massacre, enslavement and displacement; "blood and iron" is therefore a later shorthand for specific coercion.

- Army: Attention to the diwan-i-arz, new cavalry, alert exercises and inquiry into old assignments linked revenue to readiness. Political opposition forced compromises, and exact strength is unknown.
- Frontier: He fortified the Beas-oriented line, used princes at Multan-Sunam-Samana and exchanged embassies with Hulegu. Delhi survived, but western Punjab was not fully recovered and wider Mongol priorities helped.
- Bengal: Personal defeat of Tughril restored obedience only temporarily; Bughra Khan later ruled independently.
- Succession and verdict: Prince Muhammad's death destroyed Balban's design; Kaiqubad's collapse and the Khalji accession followed. Balban created a stronger monarchy and security platform, not a stable dynasty or fully centralised empire.

Why this earns marks: It evaluates ideology, source, nobility, justice, army, internal coercion, Mongols, Bengal and succession with success-limit balance throughout.

Mains 20M-3 - Sources and historiography of the Mamluk century

Question: Evaluate the textual and material sources for the Mamluk period and show how they shape modern interpretations. (20 marks, 300 words)

Model answer

- Direct thesis: The Mamluk century is reconstructed from Persian court texts, advice literature, coins, inscriptions and monuments. Their combined strength is institutional and political detail; their shared weakness is elite selection, uneven chronology and silence on much of society.
- Hasan Nizami: Taj-ul-Ma'asir offers an early Ghurid-Aibak conquest narrative and language of legitimation. Ornate panegyric, selective chronology and court dependence require separation of report from rhetoric.
- Minhaj-us-Siraj: Tabaqat-i Nasiri is indispensable for Ghurid genealogy, Bakhtiyar, Iltutmish, Raziya and the early Balban world. Minhaj's contemporary position improves access, but clerical values, patronage and office interests shape his account; his judgement on Raziya exposes gender bias.
- Fakhr-i Mudabbir: Political-military advice illuminates ideals of army, hierarchy and literate administration. Prescriptive norms cannot prove implementation.
- Barani: Writing decades later, he supplies the Chihalgani label, Balban's ceremonies, noble exclusivity, barids and justice. His high-born prejudice and normative theory make literal numbers, speeches and motives unsafe without corroboration.
- Coins and inscriptions: Aibak-Iltutmish titlature, mints, tanka-jital circulation, caliphal formulas and Qutb inscriptions offer more contemporary public claims. Circulation and titlature do not map uniform power.
- Architecture: Quwwat-ul-Islam, Qutb Minar, Ajmer, Sultan Ghari, Iltutmish's and Balban's tombs reveal patronage, spolia, craft and technical sequence. Repair phases and elite survival complicate reading.
- Silence and social history: Court texts marginalise cultivators, artisans, women outside the palace and regional voices. Local intermediaries and craft agency must be inferred cautiously from institutions and material practice.
- Historiography: Colonial "Slave dynasty/despotism" labels over-literalised status and rupture; institutional studies recovered iqta and state formation; Persianate-network, gender and architectural readings add mobility, source position and material complexity.
- Conclusion: Strong interpretation comes from triangulation: every claim should name evidence, state significance and expose what the archive cannot prove.

Why this earns marks: It evaluates five source classes, names works and monuments, links bias to specific interpretations and ends with a reusable historical method.